

The Social Radars

Founder Mode: Brian Chesky, Founder & CEO, Airbnb Released August 22, 2025

Jessica: [\(00:00:00\)](#) Carolynn, we are here with Brian Chesky, the founder and CEO of Airbnb. We are so excited to be talking to you this morning on a special topic, Founder Mode. Last year, at this very time, you came to the YC alumni retreat, and you gave a seminal talk that everyone in that room remembers where you just described what then became known as Founder Mode, and it was magical. And I wanna talk more about that. Tell us about that talk.

Brian: [\(00:00:36\)](#) I mean, the talk was, like, pretty crazy because I wasn't even planning to come. I told Garry, I I'm coming from out of town. I don't think I can make it. And then the night before the talk, Ron Conway sends me, like and Ron Conway is a very persuasive person.

Carolynn: [\(00:00:49\)](#) The best.

Brian: [\(00:00:50\)](#) Me a text message. I think it was, like, in all caps. Like, you have to come, like, support founders. Like, they have to hear what you're gonna say. And I'm like, okay.

And I think, like, the schedule is, like, already printed. And, like, Steve Hoffman was supposed to last talk. I told Garry, okay. I'll come. And I remember driving.

I think it's like it was like so it was like I got there so late. Was like dark. It was like nine or 09:30. I get on and I'm only supposed to go on for like twenty, thirty minutes. I don't even really know what I'm gonna say except I speak a lot of Y Combinator and I speak up the founding story.

And I thought, well, there's almost like a refounding story. There's this thing that happened from the pandemic to today. I needed to tell the story. And I thought there was something about YC where there's a sense of togetherness. Before YC, I didn't know what I was doing.

I thought we needed business plans. PG was like, do things that don't scale and like make something people want. And we had this methodology and there was this like way to do something and we did it and it worked. And we had other founder friends and we talked to each other and they did things and it worked. And then suddenly you go on a rocket ship and you're alone in that rocket ship.

And in that rocket ship, it is so lonely because number one, your co founders start working for you. And so suddenly you're not totally equal if you're the CEO. And then you start hiring these executives. And these executives are typically older than you and they're much more experienced and they're like adults and you're like an adolescent. That's the that's the least what I felt like.

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I think a lot of people feel the way. And you don't know quite what to do, and we didn't have the same community. And so the people telling us what to do or giving us advice weren't Paul Graham, weren't other YC founders, weren't other YC alum. It's the people we hired the people on our board who have maybe good intentions, but they're telling us how to run a big company with a professional CEO. And that is not who we were.

And so they're telling you things like hire great people and trust them to do their job. It and that how could you disagree with that? Right. Doesn't wanna hire great people and trust them to do their job? And I did it, and it was incredibly fatal because I misunderstood for hire them and let them do their thing without auditing what they were doing.

And suddenly, you might find out a couple years later, they maybe weren't the right people. They weren't doing the right thing. They hired the wrong team. And guess what? They'll leave and you have to now fix it for like five years.

And this can happen over and over and over and over again. And I kind of felt like when we started Airbnb, we ran the company that we wanted to run. And then we hired people. And again, people with good intentions. But I naturally I think I'm a I think I was a little bit of a people pleaser.

I think a lot of founders, like, we're a little bit we can be people pleasers. We want to be liked. We want these people to work for us to like working for us. And so we listen to them and we ask them, like, kind of how they want to be led and what we should do. And what you end up doing is with good intentions.

You basically try to find some negotiations, some midpoint between how you want to run the company and how they want to be led, except each of them have their own perspectives. No one agrees on anything. So you're kind of negotiating with everyone who's going in every different direction, and they're competing with each other. And many of them, if you're doing this as long as I am, seventeen years, what you end up doing is going through many generations of this where people say, let me do my thing. They do their thing with their team leave.

And then you inherit their team and you have to keep doing their thing. But then you hire someone else who wants to do a different thing, Not that thing that they were trying to do. And do this with 20 different groups.

Jessica:

[\(00:04:28\)](#)

I'm so confused.

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Brian: [\(00:04:30\)](#) In different directions. And so suddenly, you start to wanna get more hands on. You have to fix things. You're saying, okay. Now we're gonna do this.

And people are like, why aren't you trusting me? Why aren't you empowering me? You're like, you're you're you're meddling. Like, you're micromanaging me. There's all these terms.

They're all negative. They all come from this notion that you don't know what you're doing. You're not a good leader. You don't trust yourself. You start listening to everyone but your inner voice.

And that's when you become a manager, not a founder. And I just like I started thinking I was crazy. And the bigger we got and the more successful we got, the more I lost my confidence. You think I would have gained my confidence. Yeah.

But I started losing my confidence because the thing was out scaling me and I didn't quite know what to do and I was basically seeking advice and I should have listened to myself how I want to run the company. Because the right way is one way and that's the only way. And that the way is the way you wanna do it because people some people will stick with you, but many will come and go. We talk about this thing, product market fit. There's also this thing called founder market fit.

How do you wanna run the company? You are the right founder for the right company, and you need to build your team the right way. So, basically, I went last year. I told this crazy story. I basically said, like, I felt like I lost control of my company, not from the investors, but from the employees.

Like, I just we were all going in thousand different directions, and I didn't know what to do. I started basically seeking out advice. I discovered, again, the couple people came in my life that were former Apple employees. They told me how Steve Jobs, like, basically came back to Apple. He was, like, ninety days from bankruptcy, and he basically took what was basically a manager mode company and got it into Founder Mode.

And I learned I put that in my head and I said, I wish I had permission to do that, but we're about to go public. But, man, I wish I could run this company like during Y Combinator. What if we could run like a giant startup? What if we could be small? What if we could be lean?

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What if every manager was also, like, in the details of the work? So they knew what they were managing. What if people weren't focused on promotions? What if they're focused on doing great work? What if the CEO was still the chief product officer?

I was in the details of the work. What if I reviewed all the work and told people what good and bad was rather than just saying, trust you. You do whatever you want because we're one brand. We must stand for something. What if we all agreed to row in one direction?

And it was my direction that I set because I was this founder and I was the CEO. That was a beautiful idea. Except to do that, I had to basically rebuild the company and kind of blow it up. So I had no impetus, and then the pandemic happens.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:10\)](#)

There's your impetus.

Brian:
[\(00:07:11\)](#)

And when you're a travel company I remember the night of the pan the Ides of March, March 15, Ken Chenault, board member of mine, he was CEO of Amex during 09/11 and 2008. Wow. So Amex did travel, you know, they were a big travel company. And he said, I dealt with 09/11. I dealt with 2008 as a CEO.

They were my defining moments as a leader. Sometime, at some point, you're gonna have your nine 11. You're gonna deal with your two thousand eight. It's gonna happen on your watch. Something in the world's gonna happen, and it'll be your defining moment as a leader.

And that day, on March 15, Ken Chenal calls me and he said, remember that conversation I had about a nine eleven? This pandemic is 10 of them.

Jessica:
[\(00:07:58\)](#)

Oh, wow. Wow.

Brian:
[\(00:07:59\)](#)

This is the size of ten nine elevens. And it was. It was the size of ten nine elevens. That was the impact it had on travel. He said, this is your defining moment as a leader.

And I thought about this Andy Grove quote, Bad companies destroyed by a crisis. Good companies survive a crisis, but great companies are defined by a crisis. And I said, He's right. This is going be our defining moment. And luckily, I had a blueprint.

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And that blueprint we now call Founder Mode. But I'd have a name for it. I just said like, it's a company that just gets shit done. And it's and I'm not like I'm not arguing with everyone about what we're doing. It's a small team.

Everyone's really good. We go in this direction. We just do it. And my involvement. I'm not micromanaging people because I'm not telling them what to do, but I'm in the room with them.

Like when I was a founder and we're back and forth. We're brainstorming. It's not about I'm giving you space to do your job. It's not about Jessica. Go right.

Go left. It's about as a leader, we're all generally going this way, but how do you think we can get there? Great. Well, what about this? What about that?

It's a creative flow like three founders building a product. Why does it ever have to stop? And that was the creative process that allowed us to basically rebuild the company from the ground up. We went from a company that people said was gonna go out of business. Wired magazine, is this the end of Airbnb?

Yeah. To suddenly having an IPO at a \$100,000,000,000 market cap.

Jessica: And was there no pushback or less pushback because you were literally fighting for your life?
[\(00:09:18\)](#)

Brian: It was so funny. If this wasn't the pandemic, there would have been pandemonium. There would have been pushback. Again, I always say really great, wonderful, well intentioned people. That's the key.
[\(00:09:23\)](#)

It wasn't like I hire these horrible people that are misbehaving. This is how organizations are. You can hire incredible people that you interviewed, that you wanna work with. But if you don't lead correctly and you just leadership is presence, not absence. That's what it is.

And so if you lose control of your company, it's often from people where you're not giving direction. I did not have permission to lead the company. I didn't think I did. When the pandemic happened for the first time in many years, everyone looks to me and they said, what do we do? Yeah.

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Now they didn't say that when it was good. Said, let me do my thing. But suddenly, now that we lose any presence in our business, everyone's like, what do we do? And I said, oh, I guess I have permission to operate in the way I've always wanted to do. And so I'm gonna step up, took control of the company, went into basically what we I think PG Coin Founder Mode.

I went into that mode. And once the crisis is over, a few people kind of they didn't say it this way, but they said, like, okay. When do we go back to the way things were? And they don't they don't go ever back to the way things were. Oh.

And most of them were happy about that. Some were unhappy and left. But that's okay. Like, I am unapologetic. And if people watching say, I don't wanna work for a company like that, then, like, well, 99.999% of jobs aren't at Airbnb.

So you got, like, many other flavors. Like, I'm not apologizing for how we run the company, and it's not for everyone. And the most important thing is CEOs and recruiters are honest about what it's like to work there, and then people decide if they wanna be a part of that. Now I'm biased. I think in the age of AI, AI is all about speed and velocity.

I think speed and velocity is like a small team all being like we're going right and everyone goes right. I think that's those so I think founder mode companies are much more likely to thrive or even survive the age of AI because AI means every company has to reinvent itself.

Jessica: Yeah. And you did reinvent yourself. One thing that stuck out for me from the talk, and then you mentioned it again last night in your talk at the Y Combinator Founder Mode Retreat, as it's now called. Like, the idea about the skip level meetings
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Brian: Oh,
[\(00:11:43\)](#)

Jessica: Yeah. And how important that concept is.
[\(00:11:44\)](#)

Brian: I was told, like, this overly simplistic view of how to run a big company. Right? Like, there's how to run a small company. And I think, like, Paul has written many essays about it, and I think there's a lot of knowledge that's correct written about how to run a small company. But it the thing about being a founder, before I answer this question, is it's intuitive.
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Like, notwithstanding some unintuitive things like do things that don't scale and, like, kind of really simple principles like make something people want as in don't worry about, like, how you're gonna make money. If you make something people want, you'll probably make a lot of money, and we do because people want what we make. I think being a founder was intuitive. I think being a CEO is, like, not intuitive. I don't think your intuition works.

Said differently, I think people are kind of born good as founders. They're innately good founders. I don't think people are innately good CEOs. I think many of the good CEOs start as bad CEOs. I think Jeff Bezos say he started as a bad CEO.

Yeah. Steve Jobs, I mean, he got kicked out of Apple for the first time. So I think even the great CEOs started out as not great CEOs because it's not an intuitive job. And what people say, again, I think it's kind of not the way that a founder would operate. So one of the things they say is the job of a CEO is to hire a great executive team and let them basically run their company.

And that to me is absolutely not what you should do. What you need to do is you need have relationships with as many people as possible in the company. You need to be as close to the people doing the work as possible. In an imaginary world, if you had infinite time, all thousand people would report to you. Now that's not possible, but in a theoretical world, there would be no management.

Like, you could theoretically work with everyone doing the work. But, of course, that's not possible. People need direction, they need alignment, and you're not an expert in every specialty of what everyone's doing and you have limited time. So you create this, like, management layer. And management is necessary.

Maybe one day, one person can manage a thousand bots. I even think in that structure, they'll need a management structure. I even think, like, you'll need to you're you're gonna get you're not gonna be able to track a thousand bots. You're still gonna have a management structure even if you're thinking you're managing AIs. I guarantee you it's gonna be just like people.

But I do think that you need to have relationships with as many people as possible. The only way to do that is to skip level. This is what they call it. It's like you talk to if it's an as a CTO or SVP of engineering, you gotta talk to the people reporting to them. A lot of executives don't like that.

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I'm not saying all executives. A lot of executives like, why are you talking to my people? Or they might not accuse you of anything, but like, is everything okay? Or people initially, when you skip a level, they don't wanna tell you everything because they're afraid. And people get really anxious or they're like, hey.

Like, I need to be on the same page. I don't know what you're telling my team. So people for good intentions, good intentions are like you told my team direction. I didn't know about it. Or bad intentions.

I'm insecure. By the way, they don't like it. There's a responsible way of doing it though. The first thing I do is I say, first of all, they're not your people. They're the company's people or they're my people.

Like, they're we're because if the executive thinks they're their people and they leave, well, guess who has the team? You. And this has happened over and over and over and over again. First of all, I wanna have a relationship with them. Second of all, how do you know if the executive is doing a good job if you're not skip leveling?

Of course, the executives might not like that, but if they're doing a good job, I would want them to skip level. They know how good of a job I'm doing.

Jessica:
[\(00:15:10\)](#)

Right.

Brian:
[\(00:15:11\)](#)

Right? So this is only kind of a this is kind of like a confirmation bias towards the good or the bad. And then but also, like, you wanna be close to the vision. Like, what is the what is the job of a founder? I think a lot of people think the job of a founder is to, like, set the vision.

And I'm like, what does that even mean, set the vision? I think it's to set maybe another way of saying it is to set the vision every day. It's to set the pace of the company. It's to, like, shape it every single day. It's not like we just dream up something.

We tell a bunch of people and they do it. Every single day, we need to be on the journey together. And the vision, you know, changes a little bit every single day. I mean, it's the same mountaintop, but, like, the tip of the mountaintop, the way you get up it, it changes every single day. And you need to be on that journey.

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So I think of myself as concentric circles. So my directs, my directs, directs, and I treat the directs to my of my directs as my directs. So it's a concentric circle of, like, 40 or 50 people, and I treat them all as my directs. I skip level, I cohire them, and I make decisions on whether or not working out and leave the company. Like, hire, fire, promote, and manage, I co do it with my executives.

Carolynn: [\(00:16:22\)](#)
It's a lot of work.

Brian: [\(00:16:23\)](#)
But it's necessary. Now Jensen at NVIDIA took it up further. He didn't even have an executive team. I believe he has 40 or 50 directs. He just said, I don't I'm just gonna manage them all.

I think that's like if you can theoretically do it, it might work. I and he's such a seasoned CEO. He's been doing it for thirty years. I think that will be unwieldy for most people. Even for me, that's unwieldy.

That's just a lot of administration in a company. Yeah. And I don't wanna get too bogged down. But the inverse is like you have to be able to and I sometimes skip level four layers because ultimately you want to work with the people doing the work and solve the problem. And by the way, why do founders do this and not managers?

Because founders are usually more technical. They actually know usually how to do the thing. So they can sit with the people doing the thing. And the reason why is because they did the thing before they hired the person to do the thing.

Carolynn: [\(00:17:13\)](#)
Because there was no one else to do the

Brian: [\(00:17:14\)](#)
So every job in the company, I've done as a founder. Now I'd like to tell people I did it worse than you. That's why you're doing it. But every single job in the company the founder did so they can skip level because they're just doing your old job. Yeah.

If you're a manager, they came up some silo. So every other of the 20 silos are unfamiliar domains that were parallel to something they've done. They don't know about it. And they're they're just a little more wired for status. You know?

Like, it's just little things. Like, founders get their hands dirty. Like, if you're in the bathroom, there's, a paper towel. A founder will pick it up and put it in the toilet the trash. A manager will like, why is there a paper towel there?

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It's like a little thing. Yep. Because the founder was starting an apartment where if they didn't take the paper towel, throw it out, no one did. Yeah. So it's just like it's ingrained in you, and that's a metaphor.

But that metaphor is true of everything. Yeah. So I don't think all founders should or are capable of running giant companies, but I do think the best companies are when it works in the founder scale. It's unmistakable. Unmistakable in the data.

And you look at the most valuable companies in world, they're either run by founders or they have you know, the founders gave them a ton of momentum like Amazon. Or in the case of Satya, they are very close and characteristic to a founder to reinvent themselves. He acts close to a founder. He's not a founder, but he's acting close to a founder in the way of reinventing himself. And I think there's very few exceptions to this.

I mean, maybe kind of Google, but even then, Larry Sergei and Eric were kind of a trend for it for a very, very long time. Yeah. And then they have a kind of a search monopoly. But there's really not a lot of exceptions to this. You know?

I mean, once you get escape velocity, like Tim Cook was able to take the most successful product of all time and just sell the hell out of it for thirteen years. But if Steve died in 2005, would they have come out with the iPhone? I don't think so.

Carolynn: [\(00:19:07\)](#) No. Do you ever think about what where Airbnb would be right now if the pandemic hadn't happened?

Brian: [\(00:19:13\)](#) I think we would have the pandemic happened in March. I transformed the company. I made, like I made what felt, like, five years decisions in three months. And I worry that if the pandemic hadn't happened, I might still be making five years worth decisions, but in seven, three months in five years. Yeah.

And so maybe everything I've done in last five years, it would take me another five or ten years to do. And I'd probably be tired. I'd be exhausted. I'd have bags under my eyes. I'd be really frustrated.

I don't even know what I'd be telling you. I'd probably have all the same lessons, but, like, in with a lot more frustration and a lot less to show for it. You know, there's an old saying, a crisis is a terrible opportunity to waste. And man was an opportunity. I wouldn't have never asked for it.

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And I hope that people watching don't need a once in a generation pandemic. And so that's why I wanted to do this because I want to help founders, like, keep control of their company. And keep control of their company is not vis a vis investors. It's vis a vis your own team. And by the way, your employees will mostly all be happier.

It turns out I was afraid to lead. I thought I would be bossy. And I thought people don't wanna be told what to do. It turns out people do want direction. They may not only be told exactly how to do their job, but the bigger the company, the more you're yearning for direction.

Because without direction, you have politics, you have bureaucracy, you've got all the reasons why people don't wanna work at a big company.

Jessica: I love it. I think we should end there.
[\(00:20:34\)](#)

Brian: Alright. Great.
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Jessica: This is such an important concept. Thank you for being so open and sharing it
[\(00:20:37\)](#)

Brian: Oh, thank
[\(00:20:41\)](#)

Jessica: You very much. Because you are gonna inspire a lot of founders out there.
[\(00:20:41\)](#)

Brian: Well, I keep I hope to keep doing this with you and Carolyn, PG, and Garry, and I could love to keep talking about this because I think it's gonna it's really the part two to Y Combinator. It's like, you leave Y Combinator, now what?

Carolynn: Yeah. Exactly. I think the punchline here is, like, we want people to be in founder mode without having to have a crisis. So if you give them all the tools and all the content, like, they won't need

Jessica: A pandemic.
[\(00:21:05\)](#)

Brian: Stay in founder mode.
[\(00:21:06\)](#)

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Jessica: Well, thanks for coming on, you guys. Bye. Bye.
[\(00:21:07\)](#)

Brian: Bye.
[\(00:21:10\)](#)